Massachusetts Institute of Technology

iCampus Prize

Unsubscribe: Streamlining Campus Resource Sharing for a Sustainable MIT

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INTRODUCTION

The Challenge:

MIT is brimming with resources: food leftover from meetings and events, items left without owners after moves or graduations, and countless other opportunities for mutual aid.

Yet, our current systems for sharing these resources—primarily mailing lists—are outdated and inefficient. They suffer from usability issues, high notification latency, and limited reach. As a result, food and valuable items are wasted, and many students remain unaware of available resources.

The Impact:

- **Food waste:** Large quantities of edible food are discarded after events, even as some students struggle with food insecurity.
- **Resource underutilization:** Usable items are trashed rather than reused or shared.
- **Missed connections:** Fragmented communication means opportunities for sustainability and mutual support are lost.

Our Vision:

Unsubscribe is a web platform designed to centralize and modernize campus resource sharing, beginning with free food and expanding to other needs. **Our goal: make MIT a model for sustainable, connected campus communities.**

WHAT IS *UNSUBSCRIBE*?

Unsubscribe is an intuitive web platform that enables real-time, campus-authenticated sharing of resources. It directly addresses the inefficiencies of mailing lists by providing:

- **Instant, actionable notifications** for available food and items.
- **Crowdsourced updates:** Users can post photos, mark when food is gone, and add precise locations.
- **Campus map integration** for easy navigation to resources.
- **Automatic email list synchronization:** Posts on Unsubscribe appear on <free-foods@mit.edu> and vice versa.
- **Secure access:** MIT authentication ensures a safe, campus-only environment.

Why Now?

With growing awareness of food insecurity and sustainability, MIT needs a modern, scalable solution that empowers students to help each other and reduces waste.

FEATURES & FUNCTIONS

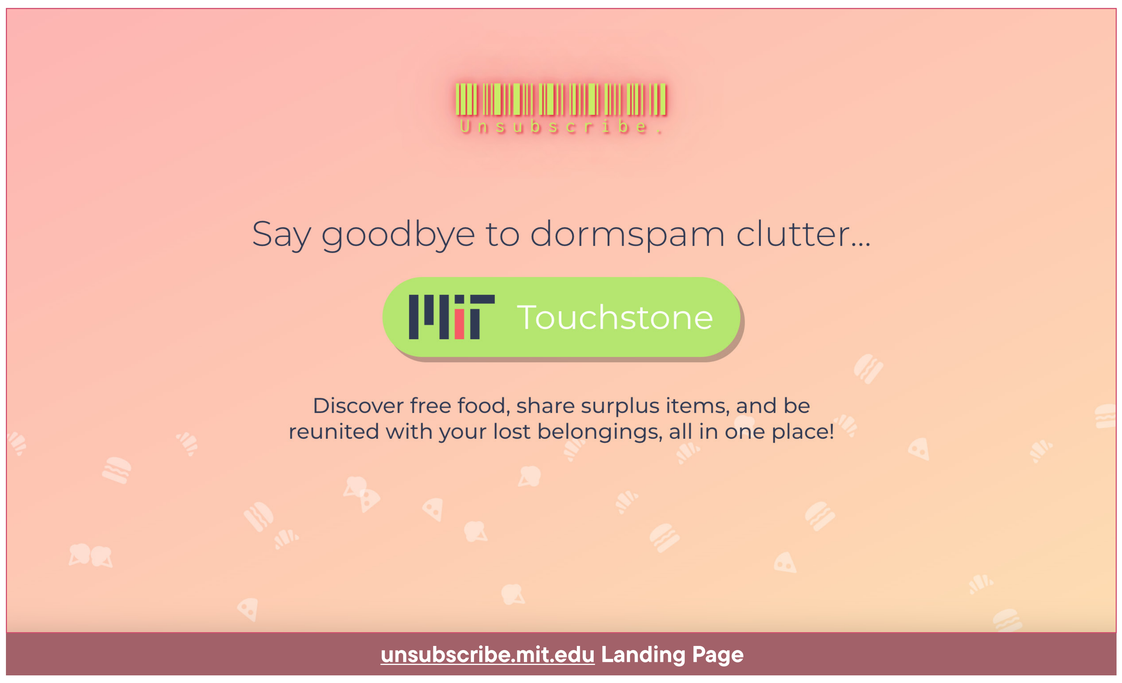
Current Features:

- Post, view, and update information about leftover food events in real time.
- Map Integration
- Email List Sync
- Crowdsourced Status
- Masterlist of MIT Food Insecurity Resources

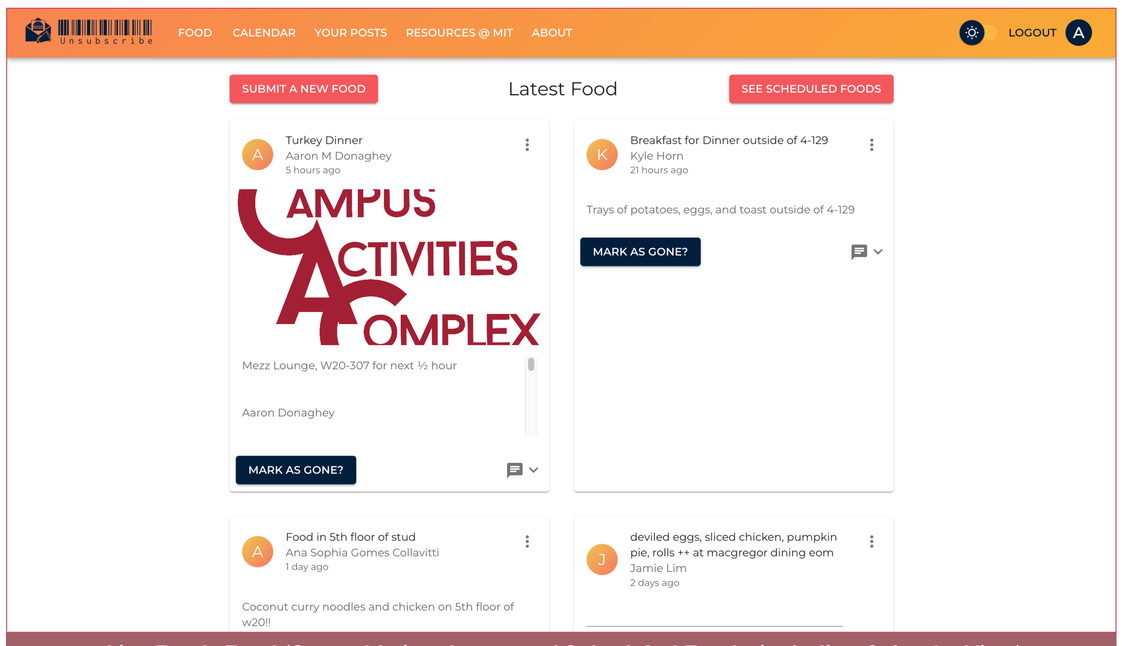
Planned Expansions (*Shrinking Dormspam*):

- **Grocery Exchange:** Facilitate sharing and bulk ordering of groceries, especially fresh produce.
- **Lost & Found:** Centralized platform for reporting and finding lost items-reducing unnecessary purchases and waste.
- **Housing Swap/Sublet:** Help students find temporary housing solutions, optimizing use of campus resources.
- **Dining Hall Menus & Food Map:** Real-time dining options and surplus food sharing.
- **Food Safety Tools:** Map of campus refrigerators (e.g., in departmental lounges), expiration reminders, and food safety guidance.

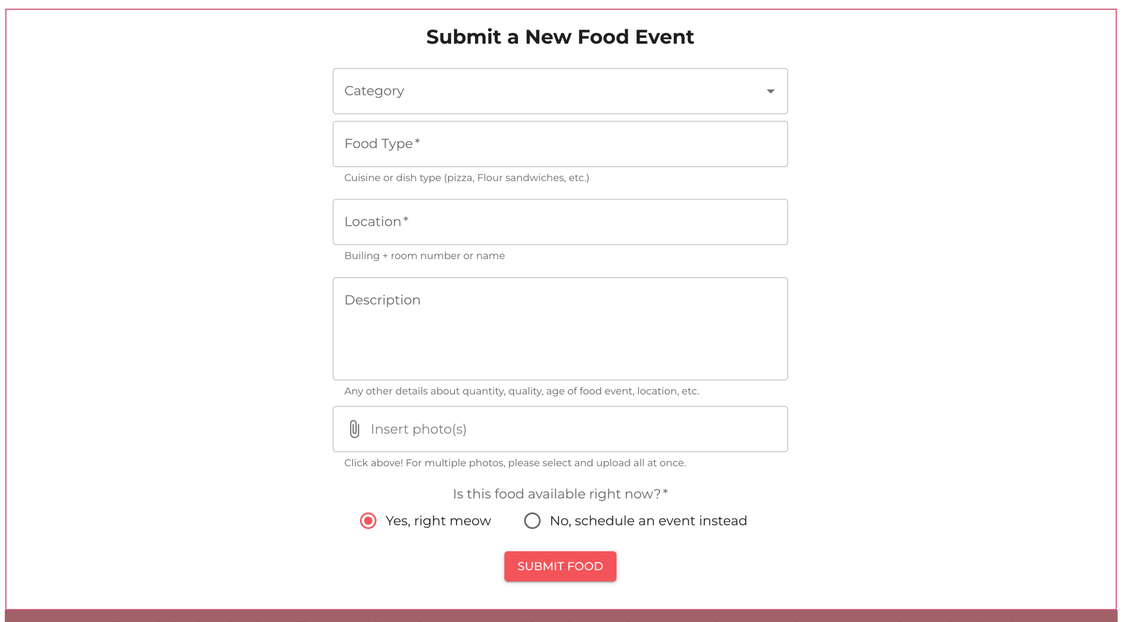
USER-LED DESIGN



unsubscribe.mit.edu Landing Page



Live Foods Feed (Separable into Latest and Scheduled Foods, including Calendar View)



Food Submission Form - Can be generalized to other needs (e.g., lost item description)

PROJECT TEAM

Members:

- **Gabriel Rodríguez Castillo:** Senior, Urban Studies & Computer Science, DormCon dining chair, SIPB keyholder.
- **Ari Peró:** Senior, Urban Studies & Computer Science and Music, MIT MCSC Scholar & TA, student leader.
- **Eugenie Cha:** Freshman, Life Sciences, DormCon swipes project.

Join us in building a more sustainable, connected MIT.

Contact: <unsubscribe-root@mit.edu> | **Website:** unsubscribe.mit.edu

IMPACT & SUSTAINABILITY

Direct Benefits:

↓ Food and material waste by connecting surplus with need.

↑ Student well-being by making resources more accessible.

- Fosters culture of sustainability and mutual aid on campus.

UN Sustainable Development Goals Addressed:

- **Zero Hunger:** Reduces food insecurity by making surplus food accessible to all.
- **Responsible Consumption & Production:** Promotes reuse and waste reduction.
- **Sustainable Cities & Communities:** Builds a collaborative, resilient campus model.

Evidence of Need:

The MIT Food Insecurity Solutions Working Group has identified both **food insecurity and resource waste as persistent problems** on campus. While large amounts of edible food are discarded after events, many students continue to face food insecurity and lack easy access to surplus resources.

Beyond food, there is a widespread need for a more streamlined and customizable alternative to current campus mailing lists. Students regularly express frustration with the **overwhelming volume and disorganization of dormspam** emails, where important opportunities are buried among lost item notices, sublet offers, and irrelevant announcements. **Many students resort to leaving these lists**, missing out on valuable community opportunities.

A centralized, user-friendly platform would not only reduce waste and improve access to surplus resources, but also address **long-standing student concerns about digital campus communication**.

PARTNERSHIPS & FEEDBACK

Current Collaborations:

- **DormCon:** Support and pilot implementation through dorm communities.
- **Student Information Processing Board (SIPB):** Technical mentorship and infrastructure.

Desired Partnerships:

- **MIT Office of Sustainability:** Align platform with campus-wide sustainability goals and best practices.
- **MIT Dining Services:** Enable surplus dining food sharing and menu integration.
- **Division of Student Life:** Ensure policy compliance and student needs are met.
- **IS&T:** Integrate with campus authentication and IT systems.
- **Peer Projects:** Explore collaboration with Hello GoodBuy, Circular, and similar initiatives for synergy and broader impact.

Faculty/Staff Feedback Incorporated:

- *Research and comply with food safety regulations*; consult MIT Dining and legal for guidance.
- *Plan for long-term sustainability*, including maintenance and leadership transitions.
- *Benchmark and learn from similar efforts* at other universities (e.g., Campus Plate [Baldwin Wallace], Food Recovery Network [Penn State]).

FUTURE VISION

Long-Term Goals:

- Establish Unsubscribe as a core campus service, maintained by student groups and supported by MIT admin.
- Expand platform features based on user feedback/needs.
- Develop documentation and training for future leaders.
- Share best practices and software with other universities to scale impact.

What We Need:

- **Advice and institutional support:** Guidance on food safety, legal compliance, and system integration.
- **Connections:** To MIT Dining, Office of Sustainability, and similar projects for collaboration.
- **Visibility:** Help in promoting Unsubscribe to community.
- **Mentorship:** From sustainability and IT leaders on campus.